

BRAND GUIDE · V1.0 · 2026-10-29

Citric Cycle

A lemon, a microscope and a soldering iron.

DIY science at academic level. This guide holds the mark, the colours, the type, the episode system and the rules that keep every asset on the same page. Pages are numbered in hex because nobody will ever cite a brand guide.

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The name and the idea

Citric Cycle is a pun with a straight face: the citric acid cycle of biochemistry, the lemon that makes sour things, and the cycle of trying, failing and trying again that every episode documents.

The cycle has nothing to do with bikes. Not once, not as a joke, not as a Short. The channel's one standing rule.

What the mark is

A lemon slice that is also an iris diaphragm: eight blades, the number of the chaos star, the octants of a polarizer rotation. The rind is a ratchet ring with eight clockwise notches, which is where the cycle lives. In the dark centre sit five seeds arranged as a Game of Life glider, the hacker emblem — the one easter egg that is allowed to be visible, lightly.



Three things it says at a glance

READING	CARRIED BY
Lemon	The flesh disc in Lemon on a petrol ground; the only yellow object in any composition
Microscope	Eight iris blades: an aperture, a shutter, a polarizer turned in octants
Cycle	Eight chevrons running clockwise around the rind; the glider moves one cell per generation

The cuts

One geometry, six cuts. The primary is a badge: lemon on petrol with the gaps painted petrol, so it sits on photos and on any dark ground. Every other cut has transparent gaps and takes the ground it lands on.



PRIMARY · LEMON ON PETROL



MONOCHROME · WHITE



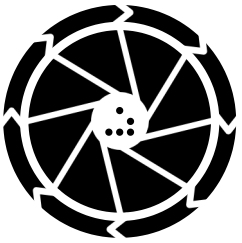
REVERSED · PETROL ON LEMON



LIGHT · FOR PAPER AND LIGHT UI



INK · ONE-COLOUR PRINT

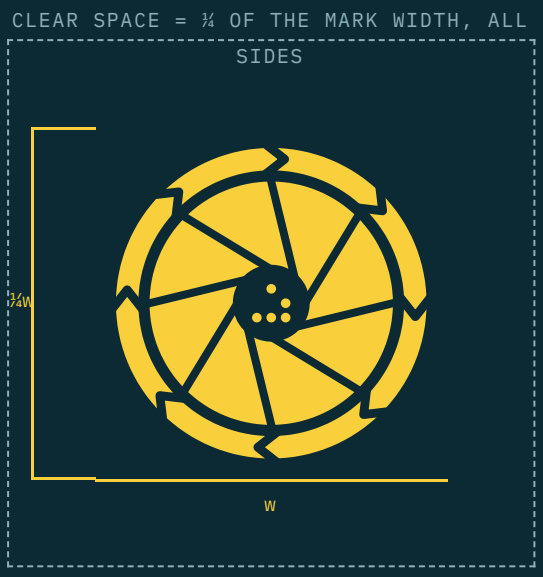


SILKSCREEN · BLACK, ≥ 20 MM

Which cut where

SITUATION	CUT	FILE
Avatars, thumbnails, banners, video	Primary badge	cc-mark-lemon-on-petrol-*.png / .svg
Dark UI, README on dark GitHub	One-colour lemon, transparent	cc-mark-lemon-*.png / .svg
Paper, letterhead, light GitHub	Light two-colour	cc-mark-light-*.png / .svg
Mono print, stamps, laser engraving	Ink petrol or black	cc-mark-petrol.svg · cc-mark-black.svg
Lemon merchandise, stickers	Reversed	cc-mark-petrol-on-lemon-*.png
PCB silkscreen, enamel pins	Silkscreen (thicker gaps)	cc-mark-silkscreen-*.svg
Watermarks, engraving outlines	Outline	cc-mark-outline-*.svg

Clear space, sizes, don'ts



Minimum sizes

- **48 px** on screen is the floor for the full mark; below that the seeds and notches merge.
- **12 mm** in print at 300 dpi; silkscreen 20 mm.
- **16–32 px** favicons use the favicon cut (no seeds, 4 notches) — never a downscaled full mark.
- Clear space is ¼ of the mark width on every side; the wordmark may sit inside it only in the approved lockups.

Angles and orientation

The mark is never rotated. A chevron always points up at 12 o'clock and the glider always flies toward 4 o'clock.



176 px · avatar



88 px · list



48 px · floor



32 px · favicon cut only

Don'ts

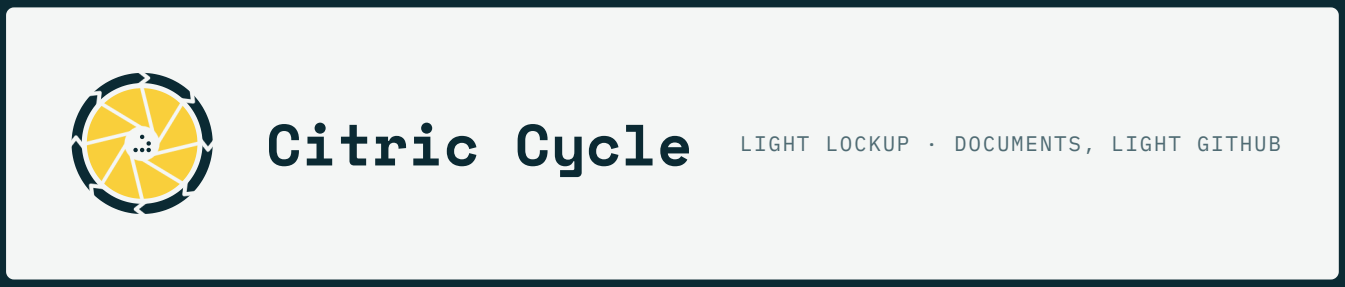
- × No text inside or across the mark, ever
- × No gradients, bevels, glows or drop shadows on the mark
- × No recolouring of the flesh: it is Lemon, white, petrol or black
- × No outlines around the badge; the ring is the outline
- × No stretching, skewing, 3D or rotation
- × No ground colour other than petrol, darkfield, lemon, paper or a photo under a veil
- × No second mark; episode icons are line glyphs, not marks
- × No wheels, chains, handlebars

Wordmark and lockups

The wordmark is Space Mono Bold, title case, never all caps, never letterspaced. It is text, so it is never part of the mark file; the lockups are the only places the two meet.







Ratios

LOCKUP	RULE
Horizontal	Mark height = 2.7 × wordmark cap height; gap = 0.28 × mark height; baseline of the wordmark on the mark's horizontal centre
Stacked	Mark above, two lines centred, gap = 0.12 × mark height; for square and portrait formats only
Tagline	"A lemon, a microscope and a soldering iron" in IBM Plex Mono Medium, uppercase, 0.06 em tracking, 0.32 × the wordmark size, one gap below
Handle	citriccycle, lowercase, in IBM Plex Mono; written as @citriccycle only where the platform shows it that way

> **Name in prose.** "Citric Cycle" in running text, "citriccycle" as the handle and the author of everything written. The first name appears only in speech and in signed letters.

Colour

Dark first. Petrol is the ground, Paper is the text, Lemon is the single highlight and it is rationed: the mark, one rule, one word in a title. Everything else is a shade of petrol.

Lemon
#F9CF3B
rgb 249 207 59
cmyk 0 17 76 2
the flesh, the one highlight

Rind
#D9A21B
rgb 217 162 27
cmyk 0 25 88 15
lemon on light grounds, badges

Petrol
#0B2A33
rgb 11 42 51
cmyk 78 18 0 80
ground and ink

Petrol Mid
#15424E
rgb 21 66 78
cmyk 73 15 0 69
panels, rules on dark

Darkfield
#06181E
rgb 6 24 30
cmyk 80 20 0 88
video grounds, end screens

Teal
#1F6B7A
rgb 31 107 122
cmyk 75 12 0 52
links on light · #5FC3D3 on dark

Birefringence
#B8236F
rgb 184 35 111
cmyk 0 81 40 28
warnings, guides · #F585C0 on dark

Paper
#F4F6F5
rgb 244 246 245
cmyk 1 0 0 4
text on dark, light grounds

Muted
#4F6B73
rgb 79 107 115
cmyk 31 7 0 55
captions on light · #8FB0B8 on dark

PCB
#1B5E3A
rgb 27 94 58
cmyk 71 0 38 63
silkscreen previews only

Contrast rules

PAIR	RATIO	USE
Paper on Petrol	14.9 : 1	body text on dark
Lemon on Petrol	10.6 : 1	titles, tags, highlights on dark
Muted dark #8FB0B8 on Petrol	7.6 : 1	captions on dark
Petrol on Paper / white	13.9 / 14.6 : 1	documents
Muted #4F6B73 on white	5.5 : 1	captions on paper
Lemon on white	1.4 : 1	never as text; the light cut carries lemon only inside the mark

> **Colour vision.** The palette was checked for deuteranopia and protanopia; phosphor green was rejected for that reason. Teal and Birefringence are never the only difference between two meanings — add a label, a shape or a position.

Type

Monospace everywhere a terminal would be at home; a sans only where a long report needs mercy. All five faces are open (OFL), live on Google Fonts, and ship in the kit.

Space Mono 700	Wordmark, titles, thumbnail words, headings. Title case for names, sentence case for titles, uppercase only on thumbnails.
IBM Plex Mono 400 / 500 / 600	Labels, captions, data, UI, body text up to ~4 pages. Labels uppercase with 0.08 em tracking; body never tracked.
IBM Plex Sans 400 / 600	Body text in reports longer than ~4 pages and in anything a stranger has to read for twenty minutes.
VT323	Hex episode tags only: 0x01, 0x2A. Never for words, never below 22 px.
JetBrains Mono 400	Code listings, terminal captures, commit messages on screen.

Sizes per medium

MEDIUM	DISPLAY	LABEL / CAPTION	TAG
YouTube banner 2560 × 1440	Wordmark 150 px	Subtitle 48 px, uppercase	—
Thumbnail 1280 × 720	1–2 words, 120–128 px	Caption 24 px	VT323 64 px top-left
End screen / lower third 1920 × 1080	72 px	26–30 px	VT323 72 px
Instagram 1080 × 1350	44 px in the caption bar	22 px	VT323 56 px
A4 write-up	Title 22 pt, H1 14 pt	Body 11 pt mono, captions 9 pt	VT323 22 pt in the header
Website	Space Mono 40–64 px	Plex Mono 15–16 px	VT323 ≥ 28 px

Casing

- Video titles: sentence case, result first, ≤ 70 characters, the hex ID as a suffix in brackets if at all.
- Labels and metadata lines: uppercase, 0.08 em tracking, separated by " · " (a middle dot with spaces).
- Numbers: SI units with a space (36.6 °C, 100 µm, 2 × 50 mL), ISO dates (2026-11-02), hex IDs as 0x01 with a lowercase x.

The hex system and the voice

Every episode is a number, written as 0x01, 0x02 … in VT323. The ID is the join between video, write-up and repository; it is not a search term, so it never leads a title.

WHERE	HOW
Thumbnail	Top-left badge, VT323 64 px, Lemon. Never bottom-right (YouTube's duration badge)
Video title	Suffix only: "Citric acid from lemons: 54 % yield, and why [0x01]" — or none
Description	First token of the first line; past 0x09 add the decimal once: "0x0A (10)"
Write-up	Header tag, metadata block, file name 0x01-citric-acid-v1.0.pdf; decimal page numbers (citeable)
Repository	citriccycle/0x01-citric-acid; tags v1.0, v1.1 for errata
Chapter cards, lower thirds	"0x01 · 02" for the second chapter of episode one
Non-citeable documents	This guide, zines, handouts: hex page numbers

Writing rules

- First person, past tense, what was actually done: "I filtered hot" rather than "the solution is filtered hot".
- Every result carries a number with units and an uncertainty where one exists; "roughly" is a number too (53 ± 3 %).
- Failures get their own section and are written with the same care as results. Nothing is hidden to look competent.
- Hazards come first on screen and in the write-up, in plain words: what it does to you, what I wore, where it went afterwards.
- Sentence case titles, no exclamation marks, no "insane", "crazy", "you won't believe". Curiosity is in the question, not the adjective.
- Citations in IEEE style; a "Cite as" line in every write-up; corrections as an errata list with credit to whoever found them.
- The handle writes; Jakub speaks and signs letters. The name never appears in metadata.

> **Licence line, everywhere written:** "Video, text and figures CC BY-NC 4.0 · code MIT · credit as Citric Cycle, citriccycle.com". Images that go to Wikimedia Commons are CC BY-SA 4.0 there in addition.

Imagery and treatment

Only our own micrographs and bench photos. Crossed-polars colour is the hero; the petrol veil makes room for type without killing it.



Veil: petrol 0.72 → 0 across 66 % of the width, type on the left, crystal on the right.



Thumbnail grammar: tag top-left, mark top-right, two words bottom-left, one of them Lemon.

Rules

- No stock photos, no AI-generated images, no renders pretending to be photographs. Diagrams are drawn flat in brand colours.
- Crop to the structure, not to the frame: the Maltese cross, the growth front, the needle tip. Centre the subject or put it on a third; never dead-centre type over it.
- Veils are petrol only, gradients linear, never a blur. Text gets a soft text-shadow (0 2px 24px, 50 % black) on photos and nowhere else.
- Scale bars only on calibrated footage, with the calibration date in the caption. No bar beats a guessed bar.
- Mark on photos: primary badge, top-right, 120 px on 1280 wide; 1/10 of the short side elsewhere. Never bottom-right on anything YouTube shows.
- Colour accuracy under crossed polars: fixed lamp, manual white balance on an empty field, no auto anything; a known retarder in frame when colour is a claim.
- One photo library, numbered P01–P12 and onward, with substance, method and objective in the file's metadata.

Assets, templates, easter eggs

Where everything lives

KIT	CONTENTS
citric-cycle-mark-v1.zip	SVG masters, PNG 48–2048, avatars, favicons, outline, silkscreen
cc-youtube-banner-B-2560x1440.jpg	The channel banner (upload the JPEG; the PNG master is over 6 MB)
citric-cycle-documents-v1.zip	Write-up and report templates (.docx for Google Docs), letterhead (.docx/.pdf/.svg), README template and header SVGs, light mark cut, fonts
citric-cycle-platforms-v1.zip	X header, Reddit banner, Instagram post and highlight covers, GitHub social previews and org README, Hackaday image, OG image, favicons
Design canvas	Rows 01–09 the mark's development, 10–12 the YouTube kit, 13 documents, 14 platforms, 15 this cheat sheet

File naming

`cc-<asset>-<variant>-<WxH or size>.<ext>` for brand files; `0x01-<slug>-v1.0.pdf` for write-ups; `YYYYMMDD_0x01_subject_cam_obj10x_takeNN.ext` for footage. Lowercase, hyphens, no spaces, versions only on things people cite.

Easter-egg policy

- Visible, lightly: the glider in the mark, the hex numbering, the generation-1 glider in the intro.
- Hidden, everywhere else: document metadata, hex comments in READMEs, commit messages, spectrograms, the last frame. One flag per episode in the form `CC{…}`, the trail starting easy.
- Never in a title, a thumbnail or a promise; never tied to liking or subscribing; no prizes in season one, so no contest rules apply.
- Nothing that survives only in pixels of images that also go to Instagram or Commons; recompression eats it.

Who may use what

Everything written and photographed: CC BY-NC 4.0 with credit "Citric Cycle, citriccycle.com". Code: MIT. The mark and the wordmark are not under either licence; they identify the channel and are not for reuse without asking. Commons uploads: CC BY-SA 4.0 in addition.

> **Change log.** v1.0 · 2026-10-29 · first issue, after the mark was signed off on 29 Oct 2026. Changes to the mark itself need a new major version of this guide; everything else is a minor one.